

PASSWITHPURPOSE

NEW
2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Paper 1

Practice Pack

Three complete Paper 1 Reading practice papers in the new 2027 format, each with original texts, a full question paper and a detailed mark scheme.

- ◆ 3 full practice papers (240 marks)
- ◆ All four 20-mark questions
- ◆ 2-mark word-meaning questions
- ◆ Marking bands for writing
- ◆ 9 original reading texts
- ◆ New Q2(b) attitudes question
- ◆ Indicative content for every task
- ◆ Student score tracker

Marcé van Moerkerken

PGCE Secondary English (Summa Cum Laude)
International school English teacher, UAE

For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All texts are original.

How to use this pack

Each practice set follows the structure of the Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 1 Reading exam from June 2027: three texts, four compulsory questions of 20 marks each, 80 marks in total, 2 hours.

Question	Text	Task	Marks
Q1	A	Comprehension: explicit and implicit meaning	20
Q2(a)	B	Summary, max 120 words	15
Q2(b)	B	Writer's attitudes and opinions	5
Q3	C	Short answers incl. 2-mark word meanings	10
Q3	C	Language task, 200–250 words	10
Q4	C	Extended response, 250–300 words	20

Three ways to use it

Full mock

Print the insert and question paper. Set a strict 2-hour timer. Mark with the scheme and record scores on the tracker.

Question by question

Use one question as a lesson or homework. Mark it together, then rewrite the weakest answer.

Tutoring & intervention

Diagnose with Set 1, teach the weakest skill, and use Sets 2 and 3 to measure progress.

Suggested timing (120 minutes)

Read all texts 15 min · Q1 20 min · Q2 25 min · Q3 25 min · Q4 30 min · Check 5 min. Each question is worth the same 20 marks, so don't let one question take time from the next.

BEFORE YOU MARK: The mark schemes give indicative content, not a list of the only right answers. Credit any valid point that is clearly rooted in the text.

Contents

Practice Set 1	The Sea
Practice Set 2	Work and Challenge
Practice Set 3	Endings and Beginnings
Marking guidance	Bands for Q2(a) writing, Q3 language task and Q4
Score tracker	Record and compare results across all three sets

The Last Pearl

Fiction

- 1 Salem had imagined this morning so many times that the real thing felt slightly wrong, like a photograph printed in the wrong colours. The sea was not the bright blue of his daydreams but a flat, milky green, and the dhow smelled of diesel and old rope rather than adventure.
- 2 His grandfather sat at the stern, one hand resting on the tiller as lightly as if it were a sleeping cat. Jaddi had not dived for pearls in fifty years, but he still read the water the way other men read newspapers, frowning at a ripple here, nodding at a darker patch there.
- 3 “Here,” he said at last, and cut the engine.
- 4 The silence arrived all at once. Salem could hear the hull creak and the slap of small waves and, somewhere beneath it all, his own heart, which seemed to have climbed into his throat.
- 5 “You don’t have to,” Jaddi said, without looking at him.
- 6 “I want to.” It came out louder than Salem intended.
- 7 His grandfather handed him a nose clip carved from turtle shell – the same one, he said, that he had worn as a boy – and a stone tied to a length of rope. “The stone takes you down. The rope brings you back. Your job is only to keep your eyes open.”
- 8 Salem clipped his nose, filled his lungs and let the stone pull him under.
- 9 For the first few seconds it was wonderful. The noise of the world switched off. Sunlight fell through the water in long, trembling ribbons, and the seabed rose to meet him, scattered with shells and the slow grey shapes of oysters. Then the pressure began to squeeze his ears, a voice inside him began to count, faster and faster, and suddenly the whole weight of the Gulf seemed to be pressing on his chest.
- 10 He tugged the rope twice, as he had been taught, and kicked frantically for the light.
- 11 He broke the surface gasping, eyes stinging, certain he had failed. But his grandfather was leaning over the side, and he was laughing – not unkindly, but with a kind of delight Salem had never seen on his face.
- 12 “Four metres,” Jaddi said. “The first time I went down, I reached two, and I cried for my mother.” He reached out a hand, rough as rope. “Again tomorrow?”
- 13 Salem looked at the water, which no longer seemed flat or ordinary. “Again tomorrow,” he said.

Paper 1 Reading • Practice Set 1

2 hours • 80 marks. Answer **all** questions. The texts are in the insert (Texts A, B and C). Spend about 15 minutes reading before you write. Dictionaries are not allowed.

Question 1 *Text A: The Last Pearl*

- (a) Give **two** ways in which the real morning was different from Salem's daydreams. [2]
- (b) Re-read paragraph 2. [2]
 - (i) What does the comparison "as lightly as if it were a sleeping cat" suggest about how Jaddi steers the boat?
 - (ii) Explain what the writer means by "he still read the water the way other men read newspapers". [2]
- (c) How does Salem feel when the engine is cut? Support your answer with a detail from the text. [2]
- (d) "It came out louder than Salem intended." What does this suggest about Salem at this moment? [2]
- (e) Why do you think the nose clip is important to Jaddi? [2]
- (f) Using your own words, explain what Jaddi tells Salem his only job is, and why he only has one job. [2]
- (g) Re-read paragraph 9 ("For the first few seconds..."). Explain how Salem's experience changes during the dive. [3]
- (h) Why does Salem feel "certain he had failed", and why is he wrong? Use your own words. [3]

Total for Question 1: [20]

Question 2 *Text B: The Quiet Crisis Beneath the Waves*

- (a) According to Text B, what threatens coral reefs **and** what is being done to protect them? [15]
You must use continuous writing (not note form) and your own words as far as possible. Your summary should not be more than **120 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 5 marks for the quality of your writing.
- (b) What is the writer's attitude towards the volunteers who help protect reefs? Explain how you can tell. [5]

Total for Question 2: [20]

Question 3 *Text C: Crossing to Musandam*

- (a) Using your own words, explain what the following words mean as they are used in the text: [2]
 - (i) **placid** (paragraph 1)
 - (ii) **resolutely** (paragraph 4) [2]
- (b) Re-read paragraph 1. What impression does the writer give of Karim? Refer to **two** details. [2]
- (c) Re-read paragraph 3. Why does the writer think the small boy's silence "was somehow worse" than his crying? [2]